Product Design Group Levels

Note: *The structure is based on global industry standards: keeping in frameworks at Meta, Google and Intercom*

Calibration Axes

- **Product Impact (Execution):** The business results you drove. This includes the projects and experiments that shipped, along with quantifiable outcomes. Most engineers have the most to talk about in this section.
- **Design Excellence (Craft) :** Work done to design better systems, improve developer velocity, and reduce/fix bugs.
- **Strategy:** Influencing the work done by others. This could be about the strategy and priorities at the team, organisation, or company level. This axis becomes increasingly important at Senior+ levels.
- **People:** Non-technical contributions such as mentorship, interviews, and onboarding. Also known as organisational impact, this is work that helps the team.

  [Detailed description here.]

Levels

- *Product Design Intern*
- **Product Designer**
  - Product Designer I *(Skill levels only, meets all expectations of this level)*
  - Product Designer II *(Skill levels only, picking up few responsibilities of next level)*
- **Senior Product Designer**
  - Senior Product Designer I *(Skill levels only, meets all expectations of this level*
  - Senior Product Designer II *(Skill levels only, picking up few responsibilities of next level)*
- **Lead Product Designer**
  - Lead Product Designer I *(Skill levels only, meets all expectations of this level)*
  - Lead Product Designer II *(Skill levels only, picking up few responsibilities of next level)*
- **Staff Product Designer**
  - **Product Design Manager** *(Parallel manager track to Staff Product Designer)*

- **Principal Product Designer**
  - **Senior Product Design Manager** *(Parallel manager track to Principal Product Designer)*
- **Director of Design**
- **VP of Design**
- **SVP of Design**
- **Chief Design Officer**

Research follows same evaluation criteria as the design counterpart.

User Researcher

- User Researcher I *(Skill levels only, meets all expectations of User Researcher levels)*
- User Researcher II *(Skill levels only, picking up few responsibilities of next level)*

Senior User Researcher

- Senior User Researcher I *(Skill levels only, meets all expectations of User Researcher levels)*
- Senior User Researcher II *(Skill levels only, picking up few responsibilities of next level)*

Lead User Researcher

Roles Description

Note:

- *Years of experience is a pseudo metric, quality of work and behaviours are key drivers of hiring and growth.*
- *To be eligible for promotions you should be exhibiting the responsibilities from the next level for a consistent period of time (min 3-6 months).*

Product Designer

Experience: 2-3 yrs

In this role, you collaborate with your manager or design mentor to tackle features or components of a product, aligning with your strengths. Your ability to articulate project goals

and design rationale is developing, with solid proficiency in one or two areas among product thinking, interaction design, and execution & craft. Your work adheres to existing patterns and demonstrates an awareness of platform constraints. Engaging in critique, you actively seek feedback from peers, follow through on tasks, and work on refining estimation skills through communication with your design manager, PM, and engineering peers.

Product Impact (Execution): 50%
Design Excellence (Craft) : 45%
Strategy: 5% *(optional)*
People: -

Skill Levels:
Product Designer I
Product Designer II *(Exhibiting qualities expected from Senior Product Designer)*

Senior Product Designer

Experience: 5 yrs +

Assigned to projects involving whole features or products within a well-scoped domain, you operate with a greater level of independence. Your leadership skills are emerging as you articulate team goals and contribute feedback to product-level decisions. Proficient across product thinking, interaction design, and execution & craft, you create clear end-to-end flows using appropriate prototyping tools. Your design process involves feedback, iteration, and exploration of various design options, demonstrating sustained self-driven productivity and reliable delivery on time estimates

Product Impact (Execution): 40%
Design Excellence (Craft) : 30%
Strategy: 20%
People: 10%

Skill Levels:
Senior Product Designer I
Senior Product Designer II *(Exhibiting qualities expected from Lead Product Designer)*

Lead Product Designer

Experience: 7+ yrs

Taking ownership of entire product spaces or projects with broad and ambiguous scopes, you deliver concrete end-to-end solutions that contribute to defining a product vision. Your leadership is solid, with strong partnerships with product managers and engineers. Proficient across product thinking, interaction design, and execution & craft, you may introduce new standards or patterns that become widely adopted. You effectively communicate your work and may represent your team in executive leadership or cross-functional forums. Actively involved in mentoring, interviewing, you contribute to design-team-wide initiatives.

Product Impact (Execution): 30%
Design Excellence (Craft) : 20%
Strategy: 30%
People: 20%

Staff Product Designer

Experience: 8+ yrs

As a seasoned designer, you've successfully led and delivered on projects of significant scope. Recognised as a leader within the design team and across peers from other functions, you contribute to setting goals and direction for the team. You excel in solving complex design problems and are sought after for your expertise and mentorship. Your influence extends beyond design into non-product dimensions, actively contributing to initiatives like interviewing, mentorship, and design standards. You proactively drive team-strengthening initiatives, demonstrating empathy and support for team members.

This level requires domain level expertise and the designer needs to be a specialist in a particular area.

Product Impact (Execution): 35%
Design Excellence (Craft) : 10%
Strategy: 35%
People: 20%

Product Design Manager (WIP)

Experience: 8+ yrs

Principal Product Designer (WIP)

Experience: 8+ yrs

Senior Product Design Manager (WIP)

Experience: 8+ yrs

Overview

	Product Designer	**Senior Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Lead Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Staff Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Product Design Manager** (TBD)
Scope	Product team (pod)	Product team (pod)	Across product teams (pods)	Operates on product vision and strategy for product area, roadmap, and innovations across teams/pods	
Ownership	Delivers end-to-end designs to solve known problems	• Delivers impactful solutions that solve customer problems and move business metrics. • Defines new feature assignments for themselves,	• Delivers impactful solutions that solve customer problems and move business metrics. • Defines new feature assignments for themselves,	• Leads design delivery across the group • Drives group's product vision in collaboration with group leads • Leads design	

		usually without requiring help. • Contributes to design efforts in building new features and contributions to the Design System.	usually without requiring help. • **Engages and inspires other designers** to engage with the community and contributes to design efforts in building new features and contributions to the Design System.	within a product team if it's short-staffed	
Autonomy	• Gets considerable amount of hands-on support • Collaborates closely with their team	• Growing autonomy, **guided as needed.** • Can independently make decisions affecting customer value/impact for complex	• Manages complex projects **mostly** autonomously • Can independently make decisions affecting customer value/impac	Manages ambiguous projects **autonomously**	•

		topics within a product/feature-set. Leads cross-product, cross-feature, and cross-team discussions related to customer value/ impact, and can bring the stakeholders to a decision point.	t for complex topics within a product/feature-set. Leads cross-product, cross-feature, and cross-team discussions related to customer value/ impact, and can bring the stakeholders to a decision point.		
Expertise	May have growth areas in some competencies, but actively learning	Comfortable across most competencies for their level	Proficient in solving complex problems	• Excels at concept design, system design, and interaction design • Highly efficient, excellent at balancing	•

				effort vs reward	
Strategy & vision	Primarily focused on execution	Contributor to team (pod) roadmap	• Major contributor to team (pod) roadmap • Defines new feature assignments for other members of the team, usually without requiring help. • Leads the coordination and management of campaigns when creating new features and products.	Contributor to **group strategy** and driver for the **group vision**	•
Leadership	Contributes to their team	• Co-leading their team (pod) with their PM and EM (Engineerin	• Co-leading their teams (pods) with their PM and EM (Engineerin	• Coaches and guides designers in their group to help them grow and deliver	

		g Manager). • Frequently sought out by product and engineering leads for opinion on both product and design direction.	g Manager). • Recognised by colleagues and community as a design authority, passively influencing discussions and behaviour, and working in sync with PM, ENG, and customer teams. Frequently sought out by product and engineering leads for opinion on both product and design direction.	impactful and high quality work • Primary product design lead for projects, providing thought leadership in selecting and guiding these efforts. Works regularly with stakeholders outside of the product. Is often the initial resource to drive design efforts for a new product or major features.	

Behaviours

These are some core behaviours that are expected from you when you are operating at your level. (Framework Reference: Intercom)

	Product Designer	**Senior Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Lead Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Staff Product Designer** *In addition to previous level*	**Product Design Manager** (TBD)

Growth mindset	• Actively look for opportunities to learn and develop • Build your self-awareness • Be optimistic and positive about growth opportunities	• Consistently seek out opportunities to improve • Be resilient when you face setbacks • Set learning and personal development goals	• Consistently seek out opportunities to improve your team or group • Know and manage your triggers for fixed mindset • Actively seek out and apply lessons and inspiration from the success of others • Proactively motivate partners by sharing insightful and relevant feedback	• Role model growth mindset for others, contributing to their development	
Communication & feedback	• Regularly communicate your work and status clearly and coherently	• Make the complex clear and concise in writing and speaking • Persuade and	• Use storytelling to communicate your work in an engaging way	• Highly effective communication skills. Writes and presents concisely and clearly.	

	• Provide rationale for your decisions • Be hungry for feedback • Appreciate and consider all feedback with an open mind	influence others with strong opinions, weakly held • Consistently give feedback in a way people can hear and apply • Be adaptive to how other people work and communicate	• Anticipate feedback to address it proactively • Communicate effectively with group and org leaders to influence their thinking and decisions • Actively help your triad and team align		
Efficiency & progress	• Make every day count • Know and prioritise what's most important	• Work autonomously but know when to ask for help • Be proactive without waiting for direction from others • Plan your work, focusing on goals, not tasks	• Be decisive to make progress, not just take action • Drive resolving dependencies with others • Maximise opportunities: when needed, go beyond the project and the role	• Help teams in your group to get the right things done, fast • Resolve deadlock situations • Coordinate design work across multiple teams • Prioritise the most impactful	

		• Balance effort versus reward • Make smart trade-offs	• Raise problems when you see them	initiatives to take on	